case. Then came the twist: Mishra was denied the BJP ticket. The beneficiary: a Sangh rookie. All hell broke loose and the BJP-ruled state was treated to the sight of a local unit blocking highways and then resigning en masse.

After a summons by CM Mohan Yadav, Mishra relented and campaigned for the party. But he broke down during a rally, an act interpreted as a signal to voters to avenge the humiliation of their beloved Dada. Analysts ascribe that to the CM's desire to not have another heavyweight to contend with.

Takeaways

- **Narottam Mishra rebelled after being denied a ticket**
- **Congress puts good face up front and plays tight defence**

YADAV'S SELF-GOAL

The result has no material effect: the BJP has 164 seats in a 230-member House; the Congress has 65 now. But it was no regular bypoll. Yadav had chosen the candidate, and a victory would have sealed his credentials as a leader in his own right—not someone appointed by Delhi. It must sting. On August 4, BJP state president Hemant Khandelwal dissolved the entire BJP Datia district executive, mostly comprising Mishra loyalists.

The Congress, by contrast, put its best foot forward after a long time. Ghanshyam Singh, first elected as an MLA here in 1993, is non-controversial, soft and affable. It was also tactful and decisive. Ex-MLA Bharti, out on bail, was hobnobbing with the BJP; the party expelled him, but waited till a day before counting. A sulking ex-BJP man in the ranks, Avdhesh Nayak, was softened up by ex-CM Digvijaya Singh apologising for a ticket denial in 2023.

As for the CM's security perimeter vis-a-vis the old guard—among whom only Kailash Vijayvargiya is in the cabinet—Datia's defeat holds a message. ■

GUJARAT

DROPPING OUT? AI TO THE RESCUE

A mix of tech and the human touch helps fight the curse of students vanishing from the school roster

By **Jumana Shah**

FOR GENERATIONS, STATES HAVE STRUGGLED with the same question: how do you stop the exodus of children from the education system after middle school? Gujarat believes Artificial Intelligence can help. No LLM (large language model) is about to wave a wand and make poverty, migration, child labour and family crises vanish. But it can predict the next potential school dropout.

An AI-based early warning system (EWS) has thus been set rolling. It works on data: student attendance, behaviour, primary health, sibling records, parental attitudes. Such data, being collected across government and grant-in-aid schools since 2022 as part of a Child Tracking System (CTS), will now feed ongoing real-time AI forecasts.

Developed by the state, Wadhwani AI and UNICEF India, the EWS, integrated into the CTS, the database sends out alerts with a customised probability for each student. Everyone from bureaucrats in Gandhinagar to district education officers can access this dashboard.

"Teachers know things first-hand and counsel children. But usually after the child drops out. Now we can move in before," says Milind Torawane, principal secretary, primary and secondary education. In 2025-26, its first year of deployment, the EWS

PUNJAB

Fissures in the Congress Camp

Pro-Channi camp raises pitch as ex-MLA gets suspended for warring against Warring

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

OVER AUGUST'S FIRST WEEKEND, from one event to another in Punjab, Congress state in-charge Bhupesh Baghel was shadowed by chants of "Channi, Channi". The *Har Booth, Congress Mazboot* campaign had just launched, but the party's state in-charge had no occasion to complain about hidden subversion. Dissent was in-your-face. Raucous supporters of former CM Charanjit Singh Channi, repeatedly interrupting proceedings, ensured that an organisational campaign turned into an embarrassing display of factional muscle.

Context: on August 1, the state unit suspended ex-Ghanaur MLA Madan Lal Jalalpur for three years, for "anti-party activities". Judging by the support he got, much of the party here would count as anti-party. Channi arrived first, demanding that the action be revoked, pointedly skipping an event attended by Baghel and state Congress chief Amarinder Singh Raja Warring. Soon, other anti-Warring leaders rallied behind Jalalpur: former min-